

Firefox May Change the Mobile Market!

TCL Communication's smartphone brand, Alcatel One Touch, launched the Alcatel One Touch Fire smartphone 'globally' last year. Fire was the first ever phone to run the Firefox OS, an open source operating system created by Mozilla. According to many, this OS is in some ways on par with Android, if not better. Sadly, Fire has failed to see the light of day in India, because our smartphone market has embraced Android on such a large scale that other OSs find it hard to make an impact. In a candid chat, **Piyush A Garg, project manager, APAC BU India**, spoke to **Saurabh Singh** from **Open Source For You** about how the Firefox OS could be the next big thing and why Alcatel One Touch has not yet given up on it.

It was not very long ago (July 25, 2011, to be precise) that Andreas Gal, director of research at Mozilla Corporation, announced the 'Boot to Gecko' project (B2G) to build a complete, standalone operating system for the open Web, which could provide a community-based alternative to commercially developed operating systems such as Apple's iOS and Microsoft's Windows Phone. Besides, the Linux-based operating system for smartphones and tablets (among others) also aimed to give Google's Android, Jolla's Sailfish OS as well as other community-based open source systems such as Ubuntu Touch, a run for their money (pun intended!). Although, on paper, the project boasts of tremendous potential, it has failed to garner the kind of response its developers had initially hoped for. The relatively few devices in a market that is flooded with the much-loved Android OS could be one possible reason. Companies like ZTE, Telefónica and GeeksPhone have taken the onus of launching Firefox OS-based devices; however, giants in the field have shied away from adopting it, until now.

Hong Kong's Alcatel One Touch is one of the few companies that has bet on Firefox by launching the Alcatel One Touch Fire smartphone globally, last year. The Firefox OS 1.0-based Fire was primarily intended for emerging markets with the aim of ridding the world of feature phones. Sadly, the Indian market was left out when the first Firefox OS-based smartphone was tested—could Android dominance be the reason? "Alcatel Fire (Alcatel 4012) was launched globally last year. We tried everything,

but there's such a big hoo-ha about Android. Last year, it was a big thing. First, you have to create some space for the OS itself, and then create a buzz," revealed Piyush A Garg, project manager, APAC BU India.

According to Garg, there's still a basic lack of awareness regarding the Firefox OS in India. "Techies might be aware of what the Firefox OS is but the average end user may not. And ultimately, it is the end user who has to purchase the phone. We have to communicate the advantages of Mozilla Firefox to the end user, create awareness and only then launch a product based on it," he said.

Alcatel's plans for Firefox-based smartphones

So the bottom line is, India will not see the Alcatel One Touch Fire any time soon; or maybe not see it at all. "Sadly, yes. Fire is not coming to India at all. It's not going to come to India because Fire was an 8.89 cm (3.5 inch) product. Instead, we might be coming up with an 8.89-10.16 cm (3.5-4 inch) product. Initially, we were considering a 12.7-13.97 cm (5-5.5 inch) device. However, we are looking to come up with a low-end phone and such a device cannot come in the 12.7 cm (5 inch) segment. So, once the product is launched with an 8.89—10.16 cm (3.5-4 inch) screen with the Firefox OS, we may launch a whole series of Firefox OS-based devices," said Garg.

The Firefox OS ecosystem needs a push in India

With that said, it has taken a fairly long time for the company to realise that the Firefox OS could be a deal-breaker in an extensive market such as India. "Firefox OS may change the mobile game. However, it still needs to grow in India. Considering the fact

